

Chapter 81 - Questions

Yan Lin's jacket was thrown into the washing machine by Feng Yue. The laundry room was quiet, and apart from the sound of the machine running, Feng Yue couldn't hear anything else.

She leaned against the washing machine, slowly crouched down, and rubbed her face helplessly and in annoyance.

Today was really too embarrassing.

Although Feng Yue was annoyed by her own reaction, she couldn't help but recall the words Yan Lin had said in the kitchen.

Hope of living...

Did she really still have hope?

Feng Yue turned to look at the bare tree branches outside the window, lost in thought. When spring winds came, this tree could be reborn, but when spring arrived, what awaited her would be her destined death.

When Feng Yue came out of the laundry room and walked to the yard gate, she saw Yan Lin and her grandfather playing chess.

Looking at the familiar scene of the two playing against each other, Feng Yue's mind uncontrollably recalled some past events.

Back then, she and Yan Lin had just started dating not long ago, but in her excitement, she still pulled Yan Lin to her grandfather's house to show her to him.

Feng Yue's family was no stranger to Yan Lin, and Feng Yue never concealed her fondness for Yan Lin in front of them.

The first time she brought Yan Lin to her grandfather's house, they had sat just like now at the small table beside the living room, quietly playing against each other.

Feng Yue wasn't skilled at Go¹, but she could understand a little. The two players were probably both representatives of the gentle school², playing with careful and measured moves.

Feng Yue had forgotten who won that match, but she still remembered that evening when she and Yan Lin were preparing to leave, her grandfather secretly called her aside and said to her: "Nuannuan³, your eye for people is good. This child has a steady temperament and treats people reliably. She's not the type to mess around outside."

Feng Yue had been very happy at the time. Her grandfather was an especially serious person, so hearing words of praise from him was particularly rare.

Judging from what happened later, her grandfather's words weren't wrong either. Yan Lin indeed had a steady character and treated people reliably, and didn't mess around outside - she was just equally distant toward her as well.

Feng Yue stood there, her mind filled with random thoughts.

Jiang Shu saw her and followed her gaze, her heart stirring slightly. But she still called out to Feng Yue: "Nuannuan, come over quickly. What are you standing there in a daze for?"

Hearing this, Feng Yue snapped back to reality. "Coming." She gathered her thoughts and walked toward her mother.

After Yan Lin and the old man's chess game ended, Yan Lin didn't rush to leave but quietly waited for the old gentleman to finish studying the game.

When only the two of them remained, Yan Lin finally spoke: "Grandfather."

She had some matters she wanted to seek help from an elder about. In her eyes, Feng Yue's grandfather had always been a wise elder.

Hearing this, the old man looked up at Yan Lin. Seeing her hesitant expression, his sharp eyes showed a hint of displeasure: "If you have something to say, say it. Don't act all hesitant."

Yan Lin nodded slightly: "I want to ask you a question."

The old man perked up a bit: "Let's hear it."

"If someone tells me that something will definitely fail, do I still need to do it?" Yan Lin's voice was somewhat soft.

The old man hadn't expected her question to be so simple, and even felt that Yan Lin asking such a question was itself unexpected.

"Little girl, if you don't do something, you'll never know whether it has meaning. Just like how most humans are destined not to live past a hundred years - why do we still strive to live?"

"I don't know whether what you're talking about is work-related or relationship-related, but if you care more about the process of doing something rather than the result, then why not do it? Don't you already know the worst possible outcome?"

"As the old saying goes, doing it doesn't guarantee failure, but not doing it guarantees failure." Speaking thus, the old man stood up with his hands behind his back, walked to her side, and patted her shoulder.

Yan Lin probably guessed that the old man had misunderstood the real reason she was asking this question. She looked up at the old man standing there and asked: "If someone is giving up on doing this thing, how should I persuade her?"

The old man was stunned, then came to his senses: "Tell her that meaningless failure is the only true failure."

Yan Lin's clasped hands suddenly relaxed, and a smile appeared at the corners of her lips: "I understand. Thank you, Grandfather."

The old man waved his hand and turned toward everyone else: "Come on, let's go eat something."

"Mm."

—

Feng Yue had been standing by the barbecue grill busy feeding Jiang Ming, but she was also paying attention to Yan Lin and her grandfather's side.

The first to notice the two approaching was Feng Yue's grandmother, Mrs. Tan. Seeing the old man's satisfied expression, she knew the chess game had made him happy.

"Ah Lin, come eat something quickly." Mrs. Tan waved at Yan Lin with a pleasant smile, then looked at the old man and asked: "How was it? Did you enjoy the game? Who won?"

The old man's face stiffened, looking somewhat embarrassed: "I'm old, I'm old. Who can still beat these young people?"

Everyone present was somewhat surprised by these words. They all knew what level the old man's chess was at. Usually, the old man had lost before, but he had never admitted defeat so readily.

Feng Yue was also somewhat surprised in her heart. In the past when Yan Lin had beaten her grandfather, he had been quite unwilling to accept it, but now he actually conceded so readily.

"I was just lucky. Grandfather is very skilled; I'm still far behind." Yan Lin was quite modest.

Hearing her say this, the old man began talking about how wonderful that game had been, and everyone's attention was drawn away.

Seeing this, Yan Lin became quiet again and silently walked over to Feng Yue's side to help.

Since she wasn't speaking, Feng Yue was also happy not to communicate with her. The two just quietly went about their own tasks, with Yan Lin occasionally helping Feng Yue pass a plate or something.

Whether intentionally or not, no one came to disturb them during this time.

As for Jiang Ming, she had long been pulled inside by Jiang Zhao to play that game from before.

The two were like being forgotten in this small corner, with the aroma of food rising from the barbecue grill adding a homely atmosphere to their surroundings.

Seeing that Feng Yue didn't have anything important in her hands, Yan Lin finally spoke: "Ah Yue, I just had a chat with Grandfather."

Feng Yue didn't respond. Knowing she was listening, Yan Lin continued.

"I asked Grandfather a question. I asked if someone tells you that something will definitely fail, should you still do it?"

Hearing this, Feng Yue almost instantly understood the hidden meaning in Yan Lin's words. She suddenly looked up with a cold gaze fixed on Yan Lin.

It was as if she could drag Yan Lin down with her on the spot if Yan Lin revealed her destined death.

Seeing her almost murderous look, Yan Lin sighed quietly and patted Feng Yue's shoulder to signal her to calm down: "Don't worry, I only asked that question. I didn't say anything else, and Grandfather doesn't know anything."

After Yan Lin finished speaking, she felt the tense body under her hand relax considerably.

She continued: "I asked Grandfather how to persuade someone who has given up on doing something. Grandfather only told me one thing."

"Meaningless failure is the only true failure." Yan Lin turned Feng Yue's body so she could clearly see those clear eyes: "Ah Yue, we shouldn't worry about things that haven't happened yet. I don't know who told you that answer, but until something actually happens, you can't confirm its truth."

"Never give up hope."

Yan Lin said this over and over. She wasn't afraid that Feng Yue would become despondent and harm herself; she was afraid that Feng Yue would give up those hopes that could cure her, and thus quietly wait for death to consume her.

Feng Yue looked at Yan Lin. All the emotions that appeared on her face - concern, worry, heartache - were both strange and familiar to Feng Yue.

She had once desperately longed for Yan Lin to direct her gaze, attention, and these emotions toward her.

But now that her wish had come true, she didn't feel much joy or happiness in her heart.

Instead, there was a strange feeling of "so that's how it is."

So this is how Yan Lin looked when she cared about her, this is how Yan Lin looked at her when she was worried.

Feng Yue now felt like a student who had seen the answer to the final math problem after the college entrance exam - only calm remained. Yan Lin's behavior answered her questions, but that was all.

The timing of the answer was ultimately wrong, and they had ultimately missed each other.

"Yan Lin, I won't give up." Feng Yue looked up at the person standing before her, her expression serious.

"I won't give up the chance to live, and I won't let myself waste time. I don't have any extra time or energy to waste on you."

Yan Lin frowned slightly. She couldn't understand why Feng Yue was so certain about her own death date. Although she said she wouldn't give up hope, she hadn't budged on this matter.

This conversation between the two ended unhappily, and they didn't say another word for the rest of the time.

The elders present all observed their behavior, and Jiang Shu was also pondering whether she should do something.

Children would handle their own affairs, but to resolve conflicts, someone ultimately needed to take the first step.

So, not long after when the whole family was gathered eating and drinking, Jiang Shu looked at the twins and suddenly asked: "Ah Zhao, when did you say you were planning to go skiing at Tamana⁴ together?"

Jiang Zhao: "The day after tomorrow, for three days."

"I see. Will there be anyone else?"

"Mm, Catherine's and my friends all have things to do, so it'll just be the three of us."

Jiang Shu smiled slightly: "Then you wouldn't mind adding one more person, would you? Ah Lin is also here in Vancouver for vacation. If she's free, why don't you let her go play with you all?"

Footnotes:

¹ Go (围棋): Also known as Weiqi, a strategic board game for two players involving black and white stones on a grid.

² Gentle school (婉约派): Originally a term from classical Chinese poetry referring to a restrained, delicate style, here applied metaphorically to chess playing style.

³ Nuannuan (囡囡): A term of endearment meaning "little girl" or "baby girl."

⁴ Tamana (塔曼维): This appears to be a fictional ski resort location, possibly based on real Canadian ski destinations.